14. Spirit of Cricket

When things were getting tricky on that Ashes tour from hell in 2014, I went for a walk in one of Melbourne's central parks with Stuart Broad and Jimmy Anderson. We weren't logo-ed up, and wanted to be as inconspicuous as possible. To be honest, we didn't have much to shout about in any case.

We were sitting on a bench, minding our own business, when a guy wearing a 'Stuart Broad is a shit bloke' T-shirt headed purposefully in our direction. We exchanged glances. 'Here we go,' we thought. 'Cheating Poms, blah, blah, blah.' Broady's refusal to walk at Trent Bridge the previous summer had pursued him, and us, across the world.

'Mate,' the stranger said, addressing Australia's supposed public enemy number one. 'Any idea where the nearest coffee shop is?' When Broady confessed we weren't from around those parts, the guy said, 'No worries,' and walked on. He clearly hadn't recognized us. We fell about, but the 'shit bloke' didn't know whether to laugh or cry.

The incident just goes to show how impersonal and random criticism can be. It also raises deeper questions about the nature of the game. At the highest level it is played hard. Fairness is a relative term. Seeking an advantage is not a challenge to the conscience. Doing the right thing means different things to different people at different times.

So many grey areas emerge when you examine the issue in any depth. Those who took offence at Broady refusing to walk in Nottingham after the